Discussion addendum

Walter McDonald | ECON 238 | November 1, 2026

Written corrections and additional responses to accompany my November 1 solo discussion. The original recording and outside-class conversation are included unchanged, apart from volume adjustment.

Corrections: Questions 7, 8, 11, and 12

I want to correct a few things from my first recording. Ireland and the Cayman Islands are examples of successful business centers. I got that comparison backward. Ireland has skilled workers, access to European markets, and business networks. Cayman has a large financial sector and financial regulation. Low taxes are only part of the story. Many reservations face harder land deals, smaller markets, and gaps in roads and utilities. [A1, A2]

The HEARTH Act lets tribes approve certain surface leases under approved tribal rules. Mineral extraction uses other rules. Saying the HEARTH Act does not cover mining does not mean tribes are banned from mining. Tribal energy agreements can also remove some separate federal approval steps; a company cannot just decide to remove those steps itself. [A3, A4]

The roughly 24 billion dollars in National Park Service repairs is a backlog reported at the end of fiscal year 2025. I incorrectly called it a yearly cost. A backlog shows a funding and maintenance problem, but it does not prove that a different owner would do better. [A5]

I also should not have said Rochester does nothing in this area. I have not checked every university program. My suggestion is a paid project with a willing tribal partner, with the partner helping decide the goals. Ute Mountain Tribal Park is a tribal park, not simply a joint federal project. Its guided visits are an example to learn from, not proof that every national park would work the same way. [A6]

The New Zealand example is Te Urewera, the home of the Tūhoe people. Te Urewera is a legal entity represented by a board, with care carried out by the Tūhoe operational entity. It is a different legal arrangement from an ordinary sale of a park. Also, past wars between particular nations complicate some land claims; they do not make every tribe's history the same or erase present treaty obligations. [A7]

Further responses: Questions 9, 10, and 10A

Land acknowledgments draw on Indigenous protocols and practices used in countries such as Canada, Australia, and New Zealand. Honor Native Land brought a guide and a direct call for U.S. institutions to adopt them. Organized campaigns and greater public attention can help explain their spread. That is a possible explanation, not proof that one event caused it. Their spread did not itself change legal title to land. [A8]

Real Rent Duwamish gives people a concrete way to make recurring payments. It is a real action beyond a statement, but I have not shown that a particular acknowledgment caused a particular donation. That distinction matters when judging whether the words changed behavior. [A9]

On land acknowledgments, I would want proof that money arrived, an agreed project was finished, or a tribal partner gained a real say. A statement alone does not show any of that. If people gain praise for agreeing and risk punishment for disagreeing, they may repeat the same words even when they doubt them. That makes public agreement a poor measure of what people really believe.

Sources for this addendum

[A1] Ireland Department of Enterprise: Foreign direct investment. Open source.

[A2] Cayman Islands Monetary Authority: About CIMA. Open source.

[A3] BIA: HEARTH Act Leasing. Open source.

[A4] BIA: Tribal Energy Resource Agreements. Open source.

[A5] National Park Service: Deferred maintenance and repairs, FY2025. Open source.

[A6] Ute Mountain Tribal Park: Visitor information. Open source.

[A7] New Zealand Department of Conservation: Te Urewera. Open source.

[A8] Honor Native Land: Guide and call to acknowledgment. Open source.

[A9] Duwamish Tribe: Donations and Real Rent. Open source.

Park tradeoffs: Question 12

I am still skeptical of a blanket transfer of national parks. Visitors may worry about price and access. Some tribes may welcome restored control, while others may worry about the cost or the terms. People who support land acknowledgments might support a transfer in principle but object once it changes a park they use. Those are possible reactions, not survey results.

Higher fees could reduce crowding and pay for repairs. They could also shut out people with less money. Cheap entry is not automatically fair either: travel, time off, and lodging already keep some people away. A possible compromise is lower-cost access for people who need it, along with visitor limits where crowding causes harm.

Parks could earn money from guided trips, campsites, lodging agreements, and donations. Those activities still need limits on damage. Financial pressure could push any manager toward too much building or resource use. I would want clear conservation rules and funding. I would not assume that tribal or federal ownership alone guarantees good care.

When several tribes have claims to one park, an agreement would need rules for representation, voting, revenue, and disputes. That adds difficulty, but it does not mean an agreement is impossible. The public may give the familiar Park Service more trust and judge a tribal manager more harshly for the same mistake. Both should face the same evidence and standards. The outcome should be tested rather than assumed.

Closing a fragile area for a season could protect it. Closing every park to everyone would be much harder to accept. Access rules should be settled before a transfer. Sudden changes could cause a backlash that also hurts support for conservation. A limited shared-management trial seems more useful to me than an immediate nationwide change.

For evidence, I would compare repair needs, habitat, water quality, visitor access, costs, and tribal income with similar parks. I would check often and look at ten-year results, rather than waiting ten years to notice a problem. A century-long view would also ask whether the land stays healthy and the rules stay stable. Tribes could gain control and income; some visitors might face higher costs or limits. The result depends on the agreement.

Native American reparations can involve specific tribal governments, treaties, and land claims. Reparations for African Americans concern a different history of slavery and later discrimination. Both raise questions about lasting harm and who should pay, but their legal claims and possible remedies are different. My concern about people today paying for past wrongs does not settle every treaty or land claim. I would consider clearer treaty enforcement, shared revenue, or a voluntary agreement over a specific site before a blanket park transfer or moving people out of towns.